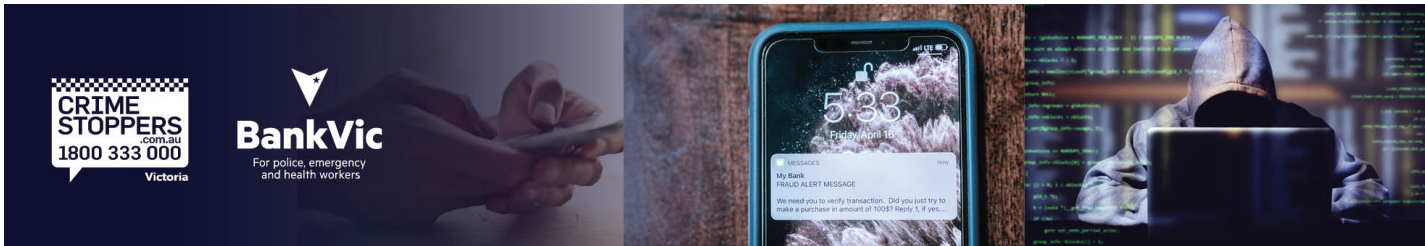




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The Scam Dictionary: The Vocabulary Needed to Recognise and Avoid Scams

Scams can take many forms, but they often speak the same language. Whether it’s a romance scam, investment scam or tech support con, scammers rely on a familiar set of emotional triggers — urgency, fear, flattery, authority, and confusion, to manipulate their victims.

Welcome to **The Scam Dictionary**: a glossary of common words, phrases and tactics that scammers use to pressure, trick or guilt you into acting before you think. Learn to recognise these red flags in conversation, text or email, and you’ll be much harder to fool.

▶ “Urgent” / “Act Now” / “Immediate Action Required”
▶ “You’ve Been Selected” / “Congratulations”
▶ “There’s a Problem With Your Account”
▶ “Verify Your Identity” / “Confirm Your Details”
▶ “We are from the Government / Police / ATO”
▶ “Keep This Confidential” / “Don’t Tell Anyone”
▶ “Just a Small Fee” / “Processing Costs Apply”
▶ “Guaranteed Returns” / “No Risk”
▶ “Trust Me” / “I Wouldn’t Lie to You”
▶ “Click Here” / “Login Below”
▶ “We’re Experiencing Delays” / “Payment Issues”
▶ “I Need Help” / “It’s an Emergency”

One-Word Red Flags

Sometimes, just one word can reveal a scammer’s intentions, you just need to know what to look for. These words are designed to provoke emotional reactions or suggest urgency, importance, or exclusivity.

- **Urgent** – Pushes panic and creates false time pressure.
- **Congratulations** – Plays on excitement and ego.
- **Verify** – Sounds official but is often a phishing tactic.
- **Alert** – Designed to shock and pressure.
- **Important** – Makes the message feel official or time-sensitive.
- **Update** – Often used to prompt you to click a link or enter details.
- **Reminder** – Creates a sense of obligation or deadline.
- **Security** – Implies legitimacy but may be used to lure you into a trap.
- **Free** – Attracts attention but often comes with hidden costs.
- **Gift** – Suggests generosity, but is commonly used in phishing and fake giveaway scams.
- **Winner** – Inflates your sense of reward, but usually there’s no prize.
- **Notice** – Sounds formal, making the scam seem more credible.



- **Final** – Suggests a last chance or consequence to force quick action.
- **Now** – Removes the option to pause or think.

If the language makes you panic, pause!

Scams are designed to short-circuit your instincts. They exploit emotion, not logic. So if something makes you feel **rushed, flattered, threatened**, or **alone** — stop. Ask yourself:

- *Who is this?*
- *Why are they contacting me this way?*
- *What are they asking me to do?*
- *Does this feel off?*

If the answer is “yes” — talk to someone you trust or report it to [Scamwatch](#).

Scammers rely on words to manipulate, mislead and pressure. But when you learn the language of a scam, you learn to spot the tricks. The Scam Dictionary helps you read between the lines, because with a scam-safe vocabulary, you are harder to fool.

Scam Safety Hub

We’ve partnered with [BankVic](#) to help keep our community safe from scams and criminal activity while online! Stay up to date with the latest tips and information in one convenient place, empowering you to prevent online crime and outsmart scammers. Together, we can create a safer internet for everyone!

Read articles [here](#).

Been scammed?

- › Step 1
- › Step 2
- › Step 3
- › Step 4

Smart Scam Guide

***Download** a comprehensive guide to spotting scams. Download to learn about the most common scams and what to do if you have fallen victim to one.*

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